

Canon Pixma IP 1600

For The Fast *Photo*-holic

A slightly higher-end look-alike of the IP 1200, this one offers much of the same thing. It's more suitable for photo printing, and is one of the fastest entry-level printers we've seen thus far.

Looks And Features

The Canon Pixma IP 1600 looks identical to its cheaper cousin, the IP 1200. Unfortunately, the similarity extends to the build quality!

Performance

If the IP 1200 is fast, the 1600 is faster. A text document saw nine seconds at the high-quality setting and 19 seconds at the draft setting; very unusual. At the draft setting, there were minor anomalies in the form of streaking and a bit of blotting. At high quality, most of these issues were ironed out, and the print looked crisp and clean. The Pixma IP 1600 is therefore reasonably suitable for mass document printing; the fact that it's lightning-fast doesn't hurt either!

The IP 1600 performed well in our combi-document tests; even at the normal setting, the

text was clear. The photo was reproduced well, though the Epson C67 edges out the IP 1600 here.

The fruit basket was also done well, with nice detailing and colour blending. In high quality mode, the quality was even better, of course, and even the smallest font was readable. The contrast test, too, treated the IP 1600 well.

A4 photo quality on the Pixma IP 1600 was good—better than on the IP 1200, with vibrant colours and good contrast. Facial features were well detailed, though the tone and colour saturation seemed a little too rich. At three minutes and 52 seconds, the IP 1600 is fast, but a bit slower than the IP 1200.

This printer is worthy of recommendation as both a document and a photo printer, and comes very close to delivering the best of both worlds.



Canon Pixma IP 1600

- ▣ A good photo printer
 - ▣ Very good for text printing, especially at high settings
 - ▣ Blazingly fast
 - ▣ Tawdry build quality
 - ▣ Offers very good value for the performance it delivers
 - ▣ Good buy for the home user, all considered
- Price: Rs 4,495

How We Tested

Our test bed was an Intel Pentium 4 at 3.2 GHz on an Intel D875PBZ motherboard with 1 GB of memory. The printouts were timed with a stopwatch, from the moment we hit the Print button to the time the document was ejected by the printer. This was the norm for the text, combi-document and photo printouts.

For our quality tests, we used two text-only documents. The first was a simple one-font, one-size. It was printed once at draft settings, and this test was repeated at normal settings. This was done because these are the most commonly-used settings for black text-only documents. The quality of the printers was assessed on the basis of their ability to produce flawless printouts at both settings. Anomalies such as blurring and blotting were noted. The settings were kept constant for all the printers so they could be fairly compared.

The second monochrome document consisted of a single sentence, the first half of which was written in CAPS, while the second was in lowercase. The sentence was repeated starting with a font size of 8, going all the way up to 24. Sharpness of text was noted, along with the the points mentioned above.

Our combi-document was a PDF file with text, images, and shading boxes. Once again, we used Normal and Best mode, which are the norm for any colour documents such as brochures and graphs. The text point size varied from 12 to 2. At the smallest point size, most of the printers gave illegible results, but the degree of difference is what we noted here.

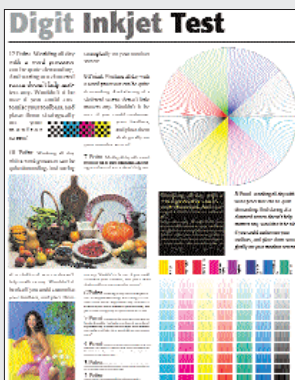
There was also an embedded photo in the PDF file, the clarity of which was noted at both the settings. We also used an image with a collection of fruits of different colours on a light blue background, faded in parts. We checked this part of the document for the level of detail on the fruit—for example, the contours on the body of a pumpkin; the texturing effect the printer could impart; and the degree of separation between fruits, for example, individual grapes in a bowl. We also checked for the highlighting that appears when light

reflects off the skin of a shiny fruit.

The PDF also had concurrent lines drawn within a circle. We tested whether these lines were straight: most inkjets have problems with this. Next, we had a contrast test, which consisted of yellow text on a black background. To make the test difficult, we threw in different font sizes, and points were awarded for how well a printer could replicate this. Imperfections were noted and points deducted accordingly. Finally, using the same PDF file, we conducted a shade test. This consisted of eight sample colour boxes, and seven columns of varying shades of colour—starting with the lightest shade at the top, and the boxes showing successively darker shades down the line. Each box had two variations in shade of the same colour, and the ability to distinguish between these two shades was something we specifically looked for. The shades should also get successively darker, following proper colour gradation.

Finally, we had an A4 photo test: the photo occupied an A4 sheet with very narrow margins on the four sides. The photo was of a person wearing a multi-coloured, heavily-embroidered T-shirt sitting on a bright yellow sofa, with a red silk coverlet lying on one end. A flower vase with white roses is in the foreground, while the background is a blue wall. There was a potted plant with lots of green leaves, behind the sofa.

We looked at the printout of the person for facial detail—particularly in the eyes, lips and teeth. Skin tone was checked, and the ability to reproduce the detail on the T-shirt was noted. The highlights on the sofa were noted, as was the detail on the shiny silver bracelet worn by the person. The sofa had a number of folds in the cloth, and the ability of the printers to reproduce these folds well—reflecting good colour gradation—was noted. Finally, the red coverlet and the bracelet allowed us to test the printers for their ability to produce vivid, vibrant colours, and the flowers were checked for detailing. The bright blue background, and the leaves with their



The combi-document used to test text and image quality